



TOWN of BROOKLINE
Massachusetts
Walnut Hills Cemetery

Trustees

*Abbe Cohen, Chairman
Patsy Ostrander
Katharine Begien*

Trustees

*Donalda Hingston
Joslin Ham Murphy
William Arthur Reilly*

**Walnut Hills Cemetery Trustees Meeting
Wednesday, March 21st, 2012
Walnut Hills Cemetery Office
5:30 – 7:00 pm**

Trustees Present: Abbe Cohen, Chair, (phone) Patricia Ostrander, Joslin Ham Murphy, Arthur Reilly

Staff Present: Erin Gallentine, Director of Parks and Open Space, Liz Scott, Park Clerk

1. Signed Deeds

2. Minutes

Minutes were reviewed and approved for last meeting. J. Murphy motioned to accept the minutes. A. Reilly seconded.

3. Current Status of Site 5

The newly built out area, named “Meadow Ledge” by the Walnut Hills Cemetery Trustees, has overall been a success. The Town is going to oversee the open lawn area over the spring, summer and fall to ensure that the turf is well established. There are a few plants that will be replaced this spring.

E. Gallentine has been working with the Engineering Division to lay out the area and place the markers and enter into auto cad. The last step is sending to HMIS, the cemetery software company we use, to ensure a unique field for each new plot available.

E. Gallentine anticipated the new site being available mid-summer but that is weather dependent. We want to make sure the turf is established before we have people walking through the area. September seemed a good option for a groundbreaking/ribbon cutting ceremony. P. Ostrander offered to research a jazz band to accompany this ceremony.

4. Discuss Winter Damage/ Spring Preparation

Due to a mild winter there was fortunately not a lot of snow damage. We will be putting in some new spring plantings. The forestry crew planned to continue their pruning throughout the cemetery over the upcoming months.

5. Caretaker's Position and Occupancy Update

The Cemetery Caretaker position has been filled, by Mr. Bill McDermott, a retired police officer with over 40 years of admirable service. We are moving towards an April 1st move in date. The caretaker position is on the Board of Selectmen's Agenda for this week for final approval. His responsibilities are to include; being a resource to visitors during off hours and the opening and closing of access gates.

6. Road Repairs

Per E. Gallentine's request the Engineering Division developed a pavement management plan. Their estimate for the entire cemetery roadway system is \$500,000. E. Gallentine recommended that the Trustees consider starting with the areas that are in the worst condition and then reassess the overall project. For planning purposes she recommended that the Trustees plan on \$250,000 to do half of the recommended work.

7. Update on Cemetery's annual town payment

The Walnut Hills Cemetery has 3 Trust Accounts. Of these accounts, 1 is non-expendable and 2 are expendable. Half of the sales of all graves are deposited into SW01 (expendable) and TW24 (non-expendable). The interest generated from TW24 (non-expendable) is deposited into TW23 (expendable). Use of TW24 (expendable) requires a vote of Town Meeting. Use of TW23 (expendable) does not require a vote of Town Meeting.

Currently \$50,000 each year is transferred to the Town Operating budget. The Cemetery costs approximately \$200,000 to operate annually of which \$150,000 is subsidized by the Town. The Town Administrator would like to discuss a greater contribution from cemetery revenue generated annually to support the overall operating cost of the cemetery.

A meeting was held between the Trustees and the Town Administrator and staff where the Trustees voiced their concern that they still had several capital improvement projects they want to complete in the upcoming years which include; road repair and maintenance, annual tree work, and an additional build out of interment space. The Town Administrator, Mel Kleckner, requested a report of the future plans and costs. He said that he would wait to recommend an increase in the contribution until the Trustees and he could meet again to discuss these plans.

E. Gallentine asked the Trustees to review an outline of an expense forecast of 2012-2024 and 3 potential options she developed as a starting point for discussion in regards to this potential increase in annual contribution.

Option 2 outlined the cemetery increasing their annual contribution by \$25,000 which would require us to scale back on future planned improvements. An example E. Gallentine gave of this scale back was redoing the worst of the paved roads instead of all of them.

Option 3 outlined the Cemetery giving the Town an additional \$35,000 a year but splitting the cost of future CIP projects, such as roadways and future build outs, with the Town.

P. Ostrander stated this option concerned her because if the money is not available at a later date from the Town our future projects could potentially be put on hold. E. Gallentine felt if we convey to the Town their need to stay committed to the Cemetery infrastructure then it is a strong option.

8. New Business

A.Reilly suggested that we should look into residing the Cemetery office and house since it is a focal point for visitors when they enter the Cemetery. E. Gallentine agreed and made a note to speak with the building department about making this a work order for them in the future.

A. Cohen requested that the contact sheet of the Trustees be updated to reflect the current Trustees.

Meeting Adjourned at 6:30 pm.